homebuyers from tax. The latter was Lapid's flagship economic initiative. It was widely panned by Israeli economists, who said it would do nothing to alleviate the country's housing crisis, which is caused mainly by a shortage of new apartments. Netanyahu opposed it, partly because he feared a political victory would boost Lapid's standing.

Rumors had also swirled for weeks that Lapid and Herzog were trying to cobble together an alternative coalition, marrying the center-left and ultra-Orthodox parties. It was an unlikely scenario, to say the least. Lapid had spent the past two years portraying the ultra-Orthodox as the enemy. But Netanyahu saw a looming coup—a "putsch" as he personally called it. Lieberman, the foreign minister, had abrogated his party's unity pact with Likud months earlier, creating a threat from the right. Even his own party was restive: Likud members had selected a far-right slate of candidates in their 2012 primary election, turning the prime minister into one of the most liberal members of his own faction.

So Netanyahu was herding cats. From his office on Balfour Street, early elections seemed a necessary bet, and a safe one. The polls showed Likud with a strong plurality. The prime minister figured that he could return to power with a more amenable coalition.

Yet by election day he seemed in real danger of losing his throne in a ballot that had become largely a personal referendum. His face was everywhere, on billboards, bumper stickers, social media, often next to the slogan "nine years of nothing". Despite the apparent stability in Israel, voters were deeply unsettled—about the unsustainable cost of living, their increasingly fractious society, a deepening strain of nationalism and racism, and Israel's growing isolation from its historic allies in the West. Netanyahu's tenure had begun to look like something of a lost decade, a period of prolonged drift. And yet his challengers were mostly unable to articulate an alternative, offering few solutions during what was a deeply personalized, ugly campaign.

One campaign ad asked, "Who did Bibi hurt for nine years?" A succession of ordinary Israelis—students, soldiers, pensioners—faced the camera and answered "*bi*", (which means "me" as well as playing on the prime minister's nickname). "Bibi hurt each one of us," the ad concluded.

Weathering the storm